

OSPREY ZERO / OFFLINE COLLECTION

Power & water.

SAVE BEFORE SERVICE FAILS

A practical collection of complete guides and private planning worksheets. No signup required. This saved edition cannot provide current alerts.

Inside the collection.

Power outage

Deal first with essential medical power, unsafe heat or cold, and drinking water. Use battery light, conserve phone power and keep fridge doors closed. Assume restoration may take longer than expected. Run generators outdoors at least 20 feet from openings; never heat a home with an oven, grill or indoor generator. Relocate early if you cannot maintain essential care or safe temperature.

Long-duration blackout

Plan around water, essential medical power, safe temperature, food and communications rather than a restoration estimate. Reserve battery power for necessities and use shelf-stable food when refrigeration fails. Keep all generators outdoors at least 20 feet from openings. Move early if essential care or safe shelter cannot be maintained.

Generator safety

Operate a portable generator outdoors at least 20 feet from doors, windows and vents, with exhaust directed away from buildings. Never run it in a home, garage or enclosed space. Use working CO alarms and never connect a generator to a wall outlet.

Food safety after power loss

Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed. Without power, a refrigerator keeps food safe for about 4 hours; a full freezer about 48 hours and a half-full freezer about 24 hours. Never taste food to test safety. Use official discard guidance and a thermometer.

Water outage

Check the utility notice to learn whether water service is interrupted and whether an advisory applies. Use stored or commercially bottled water for drinking and essential care. Service returning does not automatically mean tap water is safe.

Emergency water storage

Store at least one gallon of water per person per day for three days; aim for two weeks if practical. Allow more for heat, illness, pregnancy and pets. Use commercially bottled water or clean food-grade containers, and keep it cool and away from chemicals.

Boil-water advisory

Use bottled water or bring clear tap water to a rolling boil for 1 minute, then cool it; above 6,500 feet, boil for 3 minutes. Use approved water for drinking, cooking and brushing teeth. Follow the exact local notice. Boiling does not remove chemical contamination.

Sewer failure & toilets without service

Stop using plumbing that is backing up or may discharge sewage into living areas. Keep children and pets away from contaminated water. Separate toilet waste from drinking water, food and washing areas, and use a contained temporary toilet arrangement until safe disposal and service are established. Do not flush blindly during a sewer disruption.

Edition 2026-10-02. First-aid content is source-linked editorial guidance, not independent clinical certification. Seek current training and qualified help when reachable and safe.

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Power outage

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Deal first with essential medical power, unsafe heat or cold, and drinking water. Use battery light, conserve phone power and keep fridge doors closed. Assume restoration may take longer than expected. Run generators outdoors at least 20 feet from openings; never heat a home with an oven, grill or indoor generator. Relocate early if you cannot maintain essential care or safe temperature.

Do now.

**Check the situation**

01

Find the outage map and local emergency alerts. If someone depends on powered medical equipment, use the backup plan and seek urgent help if that equipment cannot run.

**Make the space safe**

02

Use flashlights rather than candles. Keep refrigerators and freezers closed. Unplug sensitive electronics if power is unstable, and leave one light on to show when service returns.

**Keep air safe**

03

A generator, camp stove, grill, or vehicle can produce deadly carbon monoxide. Keep fuel-burning equipment outside and well away from openings; use a battery-powered CO alarm if available.

**Check your people**

04

Contact neighbors who may need help. Conserve phone power, use text when calls are congested, and monitor official updates.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Assume restoration time is uncertain. Reserve battery power for medical equipment, light and short check-ins, keep fridge doors closed and inventory safe water. If essential medical support or safe temperature cannot be maintained, move to a checked safer place early rather than waiting for an estimate.

Watch for.

Headache, dizziness, weakness, nausea, or confusion near fuel-burning equipment can signal carbon monoxide exposure. Get into fresh air and call emergency services. Never enter a flooded area to operate electrical equipment.

People & practical needs.

Choose one person to manage medical power and one to handle food, water and short contact check-ins. Keep children away from candles, electrical damage and generator fuel. Check whether a neighbor has the same immediate needs before assuming they can help.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

If the outage continues, plan for safe temperature, water, medication refrigeration, and a place to relocate if the home becomes unsafe. Check current food-safety advice before eating perishables after a prolonged outage.

Check the next usable option

If the outage continues, plan for safe temperature, water, medication refrigeration, and a place to relocate if the home becomes unsafe. Check current food-safety advice before eating perishables after a prolonged outage.

When the first option is unavailable

Assume restoration time is uncertain. Reserve battery power for medical equipment, light and short check-ins, keep fridge doors closed and inventory safe water. If essential medical support or safe temperature cannot be maintained, move to a checked safer place early rather than waiting for an estimate.

Questions in the field.

Who depends on power?

Name the person whose medicine, mobility, temperature control or breathing support fails first. Ask their care team for a device-specific backup plan before an outage. Record battery runtime and a reachable alternative location; a power bank is not automatically compatible with medical equipment.

What if restoration keeps slipping?

Set a household reassessment time based on the shortest essential battery or temperature limit. Check the destination before moving. Do not wait for a utility estimate to become a guarantee.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[CDC · Protect yourself during a power outage](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/response/what-to-do-protect-yourself-during-a-power-outage.html>

[CDC · Avoid carbon monoxide poisoning](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/psa-toolkit/avoiding-carbon-monoxide-poisoning.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/power-outage/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Long-duration blackout

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Plan around water, essential medical power, safe temperature, food and communications rather than a restoration estimate. Reserve battery power for necessities and use shelf-stable food when refrigeration fails. Keep all generators outdoors at least 20 feet from openings. Move early if essential care or safe shelter cannot be maintained.

Do now.

**List critical needs**

01

Identify power-dependent care, temperature-sensitive medicines, water access and who cannot manage stairs or heat. Set priorities before using scarce batteries or fuel.

**Measure what remains**

02

Write down safe water, ready-to-eat meals, usable batteries and medicine quantities. Review the inventory daily rather than guessing.

**Keep fuel use safe**

03

Never run generators, charcoal or camping stoves indoors, in a garage or on an enclosed balcony. Do not backfeed house wiring.

**Protect food and hygiene**

04

Keep cold appliances closed and use food-safety time and temperature guidance. Separate drinking water from washing and waste arrangements.

**Set a relocation trigger**

05

Choose the point when medical support, water or temperature can no longer be maintained. Confirm a reachable destination before those needs become urgent.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Build a daily plan from current supplies and reachable shelter options. Do not wait for a food distribution, public generator or rescue transport that has not been confirmed.

Watch for.

An announced restoration time is an estimate. Carbon monoxide, unsafe improvised wiring, dehydration and dangerous temperatures can be more urgent than the outage itself.

People & practical needs.

Plan shifts for checking vulnerable people and essential equipment so one caregiver is not awake continuously. Keep infant feeding, safe sleep, medicine storage and pet water on the same written daily inventory.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Share safe tasks and checked information with trusted neighbours. Charge essential devices when safe power is available and use brief scheduled check-ins. Do not rely on an internet-only plan.

Check the next usable option

Share safe tasks and checked information with trusted neighbours. Charge essential devices when safe power is available and use brief scheduled check-ins. Do not rely on an internet-only plan.

When the first option is unavailable

Build a daily plan from current supplies and reachable shelter options. Do not wait for a food distribution, public generator or rescue transport that has not been confirmed.

Questions in the field.

What runs out first?

List the current water, food, medicine and battery supply in usable quantities. Compare these with actual household consumption. Check the next refill or relocation option while reserves still exist; counting unopened items is not enough when they need power or water to use.

Which room should the household use?

Choose the safest available room for temperature and accessible movement. Do not use a garage, fuel-burning appliance or a vehicle in an enclosed area for warmth or charging. Keep the exit and sanitation route clear.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

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CDC · Protect yourself during a power outage

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/response/what-to-do-protect-yourself-during-a-power-outage.html>

CDC · Avoid carbon monoxide poisoning

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/psa-toolkit/avoiding-carbon-monoxide-poisoning.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/long-blackout/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Generator safety

HOME BUILDING / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Operate a portable generator outdoors at least 20 feet from doors, windows and vents, with exhaust directed away from buildings. Never run it in a home, garage or enclosed space. Use working CO alarms and never connect a generator to a wall outlet.

Do now.

**Choose outdoor placement**

01

Keep the generator away from occupied buildings and openings, including neighbors.

**Connect safely**

02

Use rated cords as instructed; a building connection requires a professionally installed transfer switch.

**Refuel safely**

03

Shut down and let it cool before refueling. Store fuel safely outside living areas.

**Check CO alarms**

04

If an alarm sounds or symptoms occur, leave for fresh air and call emergency services.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If there is no safe outdoor position, do not run the generator. Use battery lights and ration stored electrical power for medical needs and communications. Do not improvise a connection to household wiring or operate it indoors because the weather is bad.

Watch for.

An open garage door does not make indoor generator operation safe.

People & practical needs.

Keep children and pets away from the running equipment and fuel. Check working carbon-monoxide alarms near sleeping areas. One adult should control refueling and keep fuel storage separate from occupied rooms and escape routes.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Read the manufacturer instructions before a crisis. Plan weather protection that does not enclose the generator or obstruct exhaust.

Check the next usable option

Read the manufacturer instructions before a crisis. Plan weather protection that does not enclose the generator or obstruct exhaust.

When the first option is unavailable

If there is no safe outdoor position, do not run the generator. Use battery lights and ration stored electrical power for medical needs and communications. Do not improvise a connection to household wiring or operate it indoors because the weather is bad.

Questions in the field.

Where is the exhaust going?

Check the generator's position relative to every nearby opening, not just your own back door. Outdoor exhaust can enter neighboring buildings. Keep the required separation and point exhaust away; a garage with its door open is still an unsafe location.

Can I connect it to a household outlet?

Never feed power into a wall outlet. Backfeeding can endanger utility workers and others. Household circuit connections need appropriate installed transfer equipment and qualified electrical work. Use equipment and cords according to the actual manufacturer's instructions.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

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Generator safety · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/carbon-monoxide/factsheets/generator-safety-fact-sheet.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/generator-safety/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Food safety after power loss

RECOVERY / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed. Without power, a refrigerator keeps food safe for about 4 hours; a full freezer about 48 hours and a half-full freezer about 24 hours. Never taste food to test safety. Use official discard guidance and a thermometer.

Do now.

- ☐ **Note the time**
01 Record when power failed and avoid opening cold storage.
- ☐ **Use temperatures**
02 Check appliance and food temperatures when safe; appearance and smell do not prove safety.
- ☐ **Discard risky food**
03 After 4 hours without power or another cold source, discard refrigerated perishables such as meat, eggs and leftovers.
- ☐ **Check frozen food**
04 Food with ice crystals or at 40°F or below can generally be refrozen or cooked; use official food-specific charts.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Track the time power stopped and use a fridge thermometer if available. If time or temperature is unknown, discard suspect perishable food and use shelf-stable food. Spend scarce fuel on safe water and essential cooking rather than trying to rescue unsafe food.

Watch for.

Do not serve questionable food to people or pets.

People & practical needs.

Plan a safe meal for each person before using the most vulnerable refrigerated food. Include infant feeding and food allergies. Keep the food decision separate from medicine storage: a clinician or pharmacist must advise on a specific medicine.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Clean appliances and replace spoiled supplies. Keep thermometers available before the next outage.

Check the next usable option

Clean appliances and replace spoiled supplies. Keep thermometers available before the next outage.

When the first option is unavailable

Track the time power stopped and use a fridge thermometer if available. If time or temperature is unknown, discard suspect perishable food and use shelf-stable food. Spend scarce fuel on safe water and essential cooking rather than trying to rescue unsafe food.

Questions in the field.

Should I open the refrigerator to check?

Keep doors closed as much as possible. Use the outage time and a reliable food thermometer rather than repeated inspection. Record the temperature if it can be checked without prolonged opening; smell and taste do not prove safety.

What can move to a cooler?

Use a clean insulated container and enough ice or cold packs to maintain a safe temperature. Keep raw meat separated from ready-to-eat food. If safe cooling cannot be maintained, switch to shelf-stable food rather than stretching a doubtful supply.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

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Food safety after power loss · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/food-safety/foods/keep-food-safe-after-emergency.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/food-safety-outage/>

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FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Water outage

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Check the utility notice to learn whether water service is interrupted and whether an advisory applies. Use stored or commercially bottled water for drinking and essential care. Service returning does not automatically mean tap water is safe.

Do now.

**Find the notice**

01

Check the affected address, restoration estimate and any advisory.

**Prioritize safe water**

02

Reserve approved water for drinking, medications, formula, food and pets.

**Plan hygiene**

03

Use local health instructions for sanitation and safe handwashing without running water.

**Wait for clearance**

04

Follow flushing and treatment instructions once the utility restores service.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Inventory clean containers and safe water, then prioritise drinking, food, medicines and hand hygiene. Do not use nonpotable water in food or formula. Plan toilet and waste arrangements separately and keep them away from food and water storage.

Watch for.

Do not use heating-system or radiator water for drinking.

People & practical needs.

Give one person responsibility for clean drinking-water containers and another for dirty water or sanitation. Keep containers manageable for the person who must lift them; avoid unmarked bottles accessible to young children.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Build an emergency water supply and know how your household will handle sanitation.

Check the next usable option

Build an emergency water supply and know how your household will handle sanitation.

When the first option is unavailable

Inventory clean containers and safe water, then prioritise drinking, food, medicines and hand hygiene. Do not use nonpotable water in food or formula. Plan toilet and waste arrangements separately and keep them away from food and water storage.

Questions in the field.

Can stored water serve every task?

Separate drinking and food-preparation water from water for cleaning or flushing. Keep clean containers covered and labeled. A source suitable for a toilet is not necessarily safe for hands, utensils or drinking.

What changes when pressure returns?

Find the utility's actual notice. Returning flow does not by itself establish drinking safety after a pressure loss. Use the relevant boil-water, do-not-drink or do-not-use guide and check whether the notice has been lifted.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Water outage · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/water-outage/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Emergency water storage

PREPAREDNESS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Store at least one gallon of water per person per day for three days; aim for two weeks if practical. Allow more for heat, illness, pregnancy and pets. Use commercially bottled water or clean food-grade containers, and keep it cool and away from chemicals.

Do now.

**Calculate needs**

01

Count people and days and add water for pets and extra needs.

**Choose containers**

02

Use commercially bottled water or food-grade containers intended for water.

**Label and store**

03

Mark fill dates and store away from sunlight, fuel and cleaning products.

**Rotate supplies**

04

Follow bottled-water dates and replace self-filled stored water every six months.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Calculate the household quantity on paper and store smaller containers if lifting a large container is difficult. Keep one portable supply ready. Divide storage between safe places so damage to one container does not lose all the household water.

Watch for.

Do not reuse containers that held toxic substances, even after washing.

People & practical needs.

Build the plan around the least mobile person and the shortest critical supply. Try carrying the kit, opening containers and using the light in the dark. Spend first on safe water, essential medicines, basic food and communication rather than specialised gear you cannot use. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: calculate needs. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Do not reuse containers that held toxic substances, even after washing.

Keep essentials within reach.

For emergency water storage, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Calculate the household quantity on paper and store smaller containers if lifting a large container is difficult. Keep one portable supply ready. Divide storage between safe places so damage to one container does not lose all the household water. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Learn the local advisory system. Plan how to transport water if distribution sites open.

First decision: Calculate needs

Count people and days and add water for pets and extra needs. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Calculate the household quantity on paper and store smaller containers if lifting a large container is difficult. Keep one portable supply ready. Divide storage between safe places so damage to one container does not lose all the household water. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Do not reuse containers that held toxic substances, even after washing. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Store at least one gallon of water per person per day for three days; aim for two weeks if practical. Allow more for heat, illness, pregnancy and pets. Use commercially bottled water or clean food-grade containers, and keep it cool and away from chemicals. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For emergency water storage, keep the specific hazard in view: Do not reuse containers that held toxic substances, even after washing.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Rotate supplies. Follow bottled-water dates and replace self-filled stored water every six months. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

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Emergency water storage · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/how-to-create-and-store-an-emergency-water-supply.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/preparedness/water-storage/>

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FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Boil-water advisory

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Use bottled water or bring clear tap water to a rolling boil for 1 minute, then cool it; above 6,500 feet, boil for 3 minutes. Use approved water for drinking, cooking and brushing teeth. Follow the exact local notice. Boiling does not remove chemical contamination.

Do now.

**Confirm the notice**

01

Check that it is a boil-water advisory, rather than do-not-drink or do-not-use.

**Boil and cool**

02

Use the local authority instructions; allow water to cool safely before use.

**Prevent accidental use**

03

Avoid connected refrigerator water and ice; use safe water for food, formula and pets.

**Follow the all-clear**

04

Resume normal use only after official clearance and any flushing instructions.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If fuel or electricity is unavailable, use sealed drinking water first. A treatment tablet is an option only for microbial risk and only when its label covers the conditions. If you cannot establish whether chemicals are involved, change the water source rather than experimenting.

Watch for.

A household pitcher filter does not replace boiling during this advisory.

People & practical needs.

Keep one clearly marked clean-water supply for drinking, brushing teeth, food and medicine. Ask the care team about medical devices requiring special water. Powdered formula is not sterile; feeding plans need extra care for young or vulnerable infants.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Keep bottled water and a safe means of boiling available. If boiling is impractical, use the alternative named by officials.

Check the next usable option

Keep bottled water and a safe means of boiling available. If boiling is impractical, use the alternative named by officials.

When the first option is unavailable

If fuel or electricity is unavailable, use sealed drinking water first. A treatment tablet is an option only for microbial risk and only when its label covers the conditions. If you cannot establish whether chemicals are involved, change the water source rather than experimenting.

Questions in the field.

Does my filter remove the need to boil?

Do not assume it does. Household filters may not remove all germs, and some do not address the contaminant involved. Follow the actual advisory and the linked CDC instructions; use bottled water when boiling cannot be done safely.

How do I avoid recontamination?

Cool treated water safely and store in a clean, covered food-grade container. Keep dirty utensils and untreated water away from it. Mark the container and use a clean method to pour or dispense.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

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Boil-water advisory · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/drinking-water-advisories-an-overview.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/boil-water-advisory/>

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FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Sewer failure & toilets without service

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Stop using plumbing that is backing up or may discharge sewage into living areas. Keep children and pets away from contaminated water. Separate toilet waste from drinking water, food and washing areas, and use a contained temporary toilet arrangement until safe disposal and service are established. Do not flush blindly during a sewer disruption.

Do now.

- ☐ **Check for backup**
01 If drains or toilets back up, stop adding water and keep clear of the affected area. Do not operate electrical equipment in standing water.
- ☐ **Keep clean supplies separate**
02 Protect drinking-water containers and food. Use a designated clean handwashing area with safe water and soap.
- ☐ **Use a contained temporary option**
03 Use a purpose-made portable or camping toilet according to instructions, or a sturdy lidded container with appropriate leak-resistant liners as a temporary arrangement. Keep it stable and away from children.
- ☐ **Handle waste cautiously**
04 Wear gloves when available, close liners securely and prevent leaks. Wash hands after handling and before food preparation. Keep waste away from water sources.
- ☐ **Confirm disposal**
05 Use an established safe disposal service or locally appropriate sanitation guidance. Do not dump waste into streets, rivers, storm drains or open ground.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If no collection is operating, contain waste securely in a protected place away from living, food and water areas while seeking a verified disposal option. Do not improvise an open discharge that endangers neighbours.

Watch for.

Bleach does not make sewage floodwater safe to enter. Never mix cleaning chemicals. Contamination and infection risks are greater for children and immunocompromised people.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group. Make decisions around the least mobile person, not the fastest; avoid splitting the family without a clear, safe way to reconnect. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: check for backup. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Bleach does not make sewage floodwater safe to enter. Never mix cleaning chemicals. Contamination and infection risks are greater for children and immunocompromised people.

Keep essentials within reach.

For sewer failure & toilets without service, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: If no collection is operating, contain waste securely in a protected place away from living, food and water areas while seeking a verified disposal option. Do not improvise an open discharge that endangers neighbours. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

When water returns, sewer service may still be damaged. Resume plumbing only once its use and disposal route are safe; arrange qualified cleanup for significant sewage contamination.

First decision: Check for backup

If drains or toilets back up, stop adding water and keep clear of the affected area. Do not operate electrical equipment in standing water. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

If no collection is operating, contain waste securely in a protected place away from living, food and water areas while seeking a verified disposal option. Do not improvise an open discharge that endangers neighbours. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Bleach does not make sewage floodwater safe to enter. Never mix cleaning chemicals. Contamination and infection risks are greater for children and immunocompromised people. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Stop using plumbing that is backing up or may discharge sewage into living areas. Keep children and pets away from contaminated water. Separate toilet waste from drinking water, food and washing areas, and use a contained temporary toilet arrangement until safe disposal and service are established. Do not flush blindly during a sewer disruption. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For sewer failure & toilets without service, keep the specific hazard in view: Bleach does not make sewage floodwater safe to enter. Never mix cleaning chemicals. Contamination and infection risks are greater for children and immunocompromised people.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Confirm disposal. Use an established safe disposal service or locally appropriate sanitation guidance. Do not dump waste into streets, rivers, storm drains or open ground. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[CDC · Personal hygiene during an emergency](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/safety/guidelines-for-personal-hygiene-during-an-emergency.html>

[CDC · Emergency water](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/sewer-failure/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.